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■ TKA Nair

PRINCIPAL SECRETARY

THE TEAM BUILDER

He is Manmohan's eyes and ears and the prime minister has implicit faith in him

At the top of the PMO tree is Thottuvelil Krishna Ayappan Nair, the prime minister's eyes and ears. A former Punjab cadre officer of the 1963 batch, Nair has served in two earlier PMOs under I.K. Gujral and Atal Bihari Vajpayee. He hails from Kerala and is the prime minister's key adviser and enjoys the rank of a minister of state. Unassuming, short and slim, Nair appears to be anything but the man who virtually runs the PMO. Compared to some of his predecessors who were arrogant and brusque, Nair is a man who has all the power but chooses not to flaunt it. He is an old world bureaucrat, happy in the shadow of his boss.

The prime minister's crisis manager needs doses of high energy, as the half-empty box of wheat crackers behind his table indicates. A workaholic, he gets into office at 9 a.m. and works till late into the night. His importance lies in the fact that he executes the plans and vision of the prime minister, who trusts him implicitly. He had never worked with Manmohan earlier but he was the prime minister's first choice as his chief aide based on his reputation as a man of probity who gets things done. When Manmohan had his bypass surgery, the first one he called for was Nair. PMO officials recall when Manmohan was sworn-in for the second time, Nair was asking his officials within hours to think of ways to implement the big ticket agenda of the prime minister. "We have to make sure that the benefits reach the people," he told them. Under Nair the PMO unveiled a delivery monitoring unit tasked with carrying out the prime minister's grassroots agenda. It was Nair who suggested that the PMO should review projects like Bharat Nirman, the prime minister's reconstruction plan for Jammu and Kashmir, the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act and the